



Preparing for your Engineering interview

At Orchard we've structured our interview process to evaluate backend engineering candidates in the following areas: coding, system design, and technical depth.

We've outlined what to expect and how to prepare below.

[Coding](#)

[System Design](#)

[Technical Depth](#)

Coding

We emphasize practical engineering over theoretical problem solving. Our interviews mirror the kinds of backend challenges you'll face on the job: building APIs, handling data, and integrating systems.

The coding portion includes two stages:

1. **Take-home assignment:** a project that tests your ability to write clean, functional backend code. (~3 hours)
2. **Coding interview (virtual):** a live walkthrough of your take-home, followed by a small extension or improvement.

You can use any programming language or framework you're comfortable with. We'll focus on how you reason about problems and the quality of your implementation.

A strong candidate should:

- Understand how their code executes and can explain it clearly.
- Use SQL effectively to query and join data.
- Use AI tools to accelerate their development.
- Write readable and organized code.

Using AI:

We strongly encourage you to use AI tools in your workflow, just as we do at Orchard. We often use VS Code with Copilot, Cursor, and Claude to speed up iteration and brainstorming. Use these or other tools to accelerate your development during this portion of the interview.

Development Environment:

You'll set up your own environment for the take-home. We won't run your code for you, but we'll review it closely and build on it during the follow-up interview.

System Design

In this interview, you'll work through a backend-focused system design exercise. You'll start with a high-level product goal and outline how you'd design the technical architecture to support it. We'll be looking for thoughtful collaboration and clarity as you talk through your approach.

We're interested in how you approach ambiguity, ask clarifying questions, and turn product ideas into concrete, collaborative solutions.

We look for:

- Clear, well-reasoned technical design decisions.
- Strong data modeling instincts and understanding of relationships.
- Consideration of privacy, data integrity, and API structure.
- The ability to communicate trade-offs and rationale effectively.

Technical Depth

This conversation is about your curiosity and experience as a backend engineer. We'll explore how you learn, what new tools or ideas excite you, and how you apply them in your work.

You might be asked something like:

"Tell me about a new technology, framework, or library you've explored recently. What about it interests you, and how would you describe its value to another engineer?"

We're looking to understand how you stay current, evaluate trade-offs, and think about adopting new technologies.

We look for:

- Genuine curiosity and enthusiasm for learning.
- Ability to explain complex ideas clearly and engagingly.
- Understanding of how new tools fit into real-world systems.
- Reflection on how you've applied or plan to apply what you've learned.

We're excited to get to know you better and for you to learn more about us!

Please don't hesitate to reach out with any questions ahead of your interview.

Best,

Orchard

